



bringing in players from other nations to represent them in competitions, leveraging their Australian lineage.

Among the 26 players who were part of the team that reached the 2022 FIFA World Cup round of 16 in Qatar, eight were not Australian natives.

At present, six of the 25 players involved in the FIFA World Cup 2026 qualifiers were born in other countries and brought up through Australia's club system.

For instance, Tanzania-born Nestory Irankunda, who came through the ranks of A-League side Adelaide United, was signed by German giant Bayern Munich on a long-term contract starting in July 2024.

Uzbekistan, on the other hand, has focused on identifying and honing talent through age-group competitions, leading to a lower reliance on foreigners in their leagues — 18.9 per cent compared to 20.7 per cent in the ISL this season.

Additionally, the average age of their club squads (25.4 years) is lower than that in the ISL (26.2 years).

Uzbekistan has qualified for three FIFA Under-17 World Cups (2011, 2013, and 2023), making the

knockouts each time.

Its Under-20 team is the reigning Asian champion, while the Under-23 side secured a bronze medal at the latest Asian Games in Hangzhou.

After routing India 3-0 in the group stage, Uzbekistan's senior team reached the quarterfinals of the AFC Asian Cup earlier this year.

Following that loss, then-India head coach Igor Stimac underlined the importance of investing in youth development to create a steady assembly line of talent for future generations.

"We need to accept that Uzbekistan is working a lot better with underage groups. They are nearly dominating under-20s and under-18s. They have fantastic generations of players, and that's why the national team is becoming strong. That's where we need to speed up in India," Stimac had said after the match.

Quicksand of problems

All but one ISL team — Hyderabad FC — has its under-21 teams competing in the Reliance Foundation Development League (RFDL), but a set structure for younger age groups is still missing.

The top three teams from the

Strategy that works: Abbosbek Fayzullaev of Uzbekistan, which has focused on identifying and honing talent through age-group competitions, leading to a lower reliance on foreigners in their leagues.

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RFDL last season — Punjab FC, East Bengal, and Muthoot FA — played in the Premier League Next Generation Cup this year. However, except for Punjab, the other two teams were thoroughly outplayed by the Premier League under-18 sides, conceding 32 goals over 14 matches and losing all of them.

In the last 20 years, India has qualified neither for the AFC U-20 Asian Cup nor the FIFA U-17 World Cup on merit. The burden of scoring goals for the senior team has primarily been carried by one man, Chhetri, until he retired at 39.

Yet, some Indian internationals continue to earn salaries higher than the median wages in Japan and South Korea.

According to FootyStats, Pritam Kotal, then captain of Mohun Bagan, earned over INR 2 crores annually in the 2022-23 season, which was significantly more than the median salary of K1 League in 2021 (1.3 crore).

Gurpreet, on the other hand, earned around INR 1.77 crores, which was at par or more than at least four J1 League clubs (Consadole Sapporo, Albirex Niigata, Sanfrecce Hiroshima, and Sagan Tosu) in the 2022-23 season.

This raises the question of whether Indian players prioritise high wages over playing competitive football in Asia.

While money does serve a key role in football development, a lack of appropriate planning would only see the league go down the path of the Chinese Super League — a sudden rise in demand followed by years of mediocrity if corrective measures are not taken in time.

The ISL may no longer aspire to be an IPL-style competition but can still drive Indian football development, provided its resources and funds are used judiciously.